

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

# FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

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CHAPTER 9 · GENRE

*Genre is the promise a film makes before it starts. The shape comes after.*

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**SUNSET BLVD.**

From Dusk Till Dawn · 1996 · 108 min · dir. Robert Rodriguez ·  
screenplay by Quentin Tarantino · Dimension Films

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*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.*

## THE TWO ROADS

# STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

*Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner. This is the last one.*

*Two sets of outlaws running for the Mexican border. Both films make the same promise inside twenty minutes: this is a crime film, and somebody is going to pay for it. *Thelma & Louise* keeps that promise to the last frame.*

*From *Dusk Till Dawn* keeps it for about an hour, reaches Mexico, and then becomes a different film altogether, with no warning and no apology. One honours the contract. The other tears it up halfway through and never looks back. Harvey Keitel is in both.*

SUNSET BLVD.

## FROM DUSK TILL DAWN

1996 · 108 min · dir. Robert Rodriguez · screenplay by Quentin Tarantino · Dimension Films

Two bank-robbing brothers take a preacher and his kids hostage and run for the Mexican border, where they plan to lie low until dawn at a roadside bar.

**Why it is on the ballot.** For its first hour it is a tight, nasty Tarantino crime film. Then it becomes something else entirely, with no warning and no apology. It is the cleanest example of a film deliberately breaking the promise its genre made, and daring you to keep watching.

# BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

## IT WAS TARANTINO'S FIRST PAID WRITING JOB

Robert Kurtzman's makeup-effects company KNB paid him \$1,500 in 1990 to write the script, years before *Reservoir Dogs*. It was commissioned by an effects house rather than a studio, which tells you something about what they were paying for.

## IT WAS GEORGE CLOONEY'S JUMP TO FILM

His first major film lead, shot while he was still starring as Doug Ross on *ER*. Tarantino plays his brother, Richie.

## HARVEY KEITEL IS IN BOTH FILMS THIS CHAPTER

In *Thelma & Louise* he is the detective. Here he is Jacob Fuller, a pastor who has lost his faith, driving his kids across the border in an RV. Cheech Marin plays three roles: the border guard, Chet Pussy the barker, and Carlos.

# WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

## THE FIRST SCENE

### The promise

A liquor store, a sheriff, two brothers. Pure crime film, and very good at it.

**Why it matters:** The film makes its genre promise as loudly as it can. Remember how sure you felt about what kind of movie this was.

## THE BORDER

### The RV

The brothers and their hostages try to get through the checkpoint.

**Why it matters:** This is the last stretch where the crime story is the whole story. Watch it knowing that.

## THE BAR

### Clock the minute

Check the time when the film changes. It lands somewhere around 55 to 60 minutes in.

**Why it matters:** The switch arrives almost exactly where a classic structure would put the midpoint. The film breaks its genre and keeps its structure in the same move. Roger Ebert's summary: "For about an hour, we've been following the story of two mad-dog killers and their victims, and then suddenly a stripper in a Mexican bar turns into a vampire, and off we go."

## THE LAST SHOT

### Pull back

As the survivors drive away, the camera pulls back behind the bar.

**Why it matters:** The bar is sitting on the exposed top of a buried Mesoamerican step temple, its base ringed by decades of wrecked trucks. One reveal re-labels the whole second half: the trap is centuries old.

## AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

[OPEN](#)

### The snake was not in the script

Salma Hayek is genuinely afraid of snakes and refused the dance until she was told they would simply cast someone else — “frankly, I really needed to pay the rent.” She got through it by treating the snake as a symbol of her own power.

[OPEN](#)

### The money

Made for about \$19 million, it took roughly \$26 million in the United States and about \$59 million worldwide, then became a franchise: two direct-to-video follow-ups and a television series from 2014 to 2016. The genre switch became the brand.

[OPEN](#)

### The cast is a horror hall of fame

Tom Savini, the makeup-effects legend, plays Sex Machine. Fred Williamson, the blaxploitation star, plays Frost. Juliette Lewis plays Kate Fuller. The film is a crime picture staffed by horror people, which is the joke it is about to tell you.

01 When the film changed, did you feel tricked, or rewarded?

02 Think back through the first hour. Were there any clues?

03 Genre is a promise. Which film kept faith with you: the one that stayed a crime film, or the one that broke it?

Where to watch

Find it here → [From Dusk Till Dawn on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Box Office Mojo · Roger Ebert · Fox News

# NOBODY CALLED IT NOIR

## A FRENCH CRITIC NAMED SOMETHING HE SAW

After the Second World War, American films that had been kept out of occupied France arrived in Paris all at once: *The Maltese Falcon*, *Double Indemnity*, *Laura*, *Murder, My Sweet*. On 28 August 1946, in *L'Écran français*, the Italian-born critic Nino Frank wrote them up under the heading of a new kind of crime picture and called the mood *film noir*. The people who made those films in Hollywood had never heard the phrase. To them they were crime pictures.

## AMERICANS MADE IT A GENRE

In the spring of 1972 the screenwriter Paul Schrader published "Notes on Film Noir" in *Film Comment*, and a generation of American directors started making noir deliberately: *Chinatown* (1974), *Body Heat* (1981), *Blade Runner* (1982). A label invented after the fact to describe a mood became a style you could aim at, with a checklist: hard shadows, voiceover, flashbacks, a doomed hero, a dangerous woman.

## THAT IS HOW GENRE WORKS

Most genres are born this way. The films come first, the name comes later, and then the name becomes a promise to the audience. Once you know the name, you know what you have been promised: a western ends in a showdown, a romantic comedy ends together, a crime film makes somebody pay.

# THREE THINGS A FILM CAN DO WITH THE PROMISE

ONE

## KEEP IT

Deliver what the genre promised, as well as it can be delivered.

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Die Hard · Heat · Thelma & Louise

TWO

## BEND IT

Stay inside the genre while playing with what you expect.

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Scream · Knives Out · Get Out

THREE

## BREAK IT

Switch genres partway through and dare you to follow.

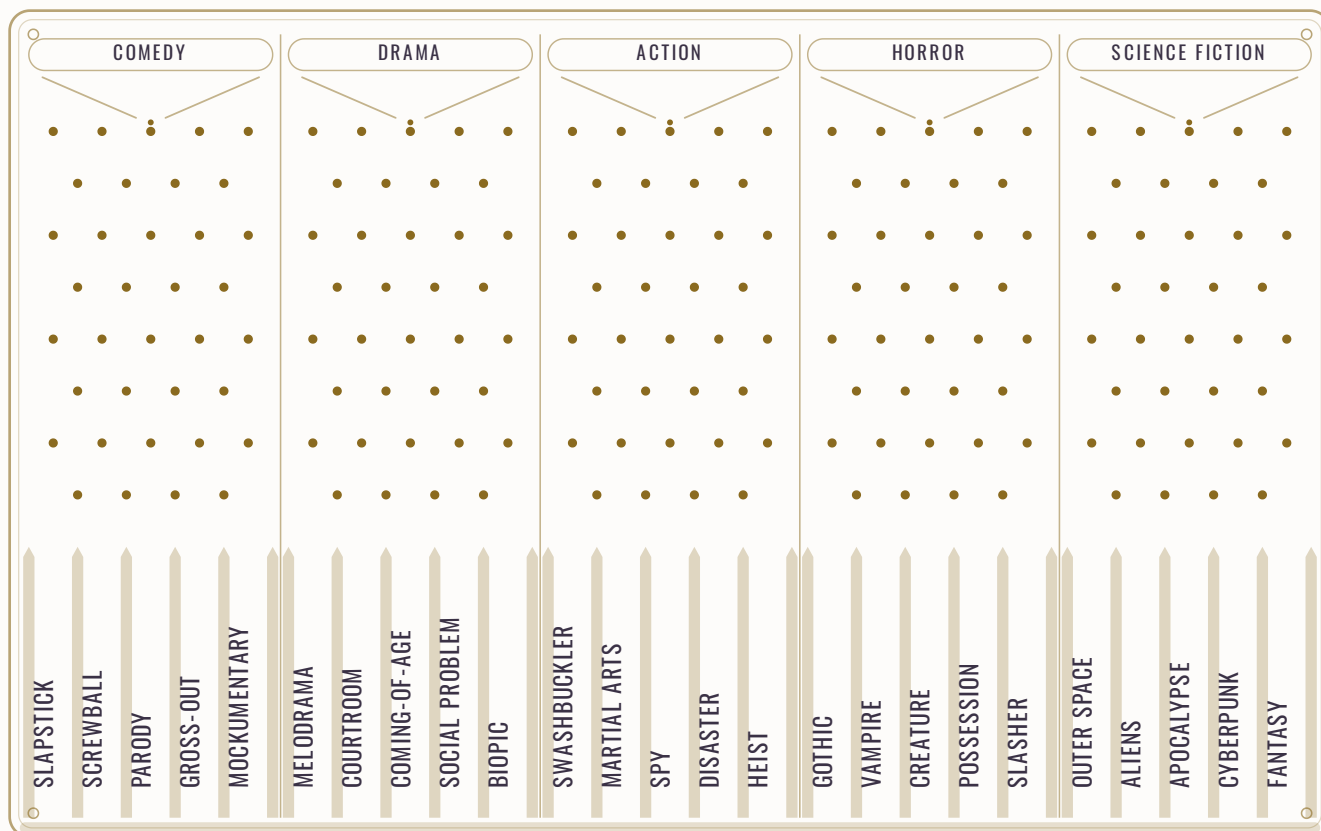
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Psycho · Audition · From Dusk Till Dawn

A genre is really a preset of everything in this book: a structure, a clock, a point of view, a frame, a cut, a sound, a kind of character and a kind of performance, all agreed before the lights go down.

## WHERE A GENRE COMES FROM

Nobody sits down and invents a genre. The films turn up first, somebody notices they rhyme, and a name arrives afterwards — often from a critic, sometimes decades late. Then the name starts working backwards, and films get made to fit it. Which is why the machine below claims nothing about what came first. It takes the five most used genres, cuts each into five of the sub-genres you are most likely to meet, and drops a ball down each.



## COMEDY

### 1. Slapstick

Bodies and objects rebel. The pratfall, the chase and the collision tell the joke, not the dialogue.

**FIRST** *L'Arroseur arrosé*, 1895 — forty-five seconds, and the first fiction film anyone made.

**MOST WATCHED** *Home Alone*, 1990 — \$477m.

### 2. Screwball

Two mismatched people insult each other into love, fast, and usually across a class line.

**FIRST** Disputed — *It Happened One Night* and *Twentieth Century*, both 1934. The word arrived in 1936.

**MOST WATCHED** *It Happened One Night*, 1934 — no gross survives; it swept all five top Oscars.

### 3. Parody

Copies one film, or one whole genre, closely enough to be recognised, and then punctures it.

**FIRST** Usually *The Little Train Robbery*, 1905 — children robbing a train two years after the real one. Thinly evidenced.

**MOST WATCHED** *Austin Powers in Goldmember*, 2002 — \$296m.

### 4. Gross-out

Aimed at the gag reflex. Bodily fluids, taboo and bad taste, all played for the laugh.

**FIRST** Disputed — *Pink Flamingos*, 1972, is the archetype; the press first used the phrase for *Animal House*, 1978.

**MOST WATCHED** *The Hangover*, 2009 — \$466m.

### 5. Mockumentary

Fiction shot and cut as a documentary, so that the form itself is the joke.

**FIRST** Disputed — *David Holzman's Diary*, 1967, or *Take the Money and Run*, 1969. *Spinal Tap*, 1984, only fixed it.

**MOST WATCHED** *Borat*, 2006 — \$262m.

## DRAMA

### 1. Melodrama

Emotion at maximum. Virtue suffers, fate is cruel, and the score tells you exactly what to feel.

**FIRST** None — it walked in from the nineteenth-century stage already finished. Griffith set its film shape, *Way Down East*, 1920.

**MOST WATCHED** *Gone with the Wind*, 1939 — \$3.4bn adjusted, still the largest audience ever sold.

### 2. Courtroom

The story happens in one room, where talk is the action and a verdict is the clock.

**FIRST** Unsettled — *Falsely Accused!*, 1908, is the earliest title cited and barely documented. *The Passion of Joan of Arc*, 1928, is the earliest anyone screens.

**MOST WATCHED** *A Few Good Men*, 1992 — \$243m.

### 3. Coming-of-age

One summer, or one year, in which a young person crosses a line and cannot go back over it.

**FIRST** Nobody names one. *Zéro de conduite*, 1933, *Rebel Without a Cause*, 1955, and *The 400 Blows*, 1959, are all put forward.

**MOST WATCHED** *Grease*, 1978 — \$396m.

### 4. Social problem

Puts a named injustice on trial through one ordinary person who has to live inside it.

**FIRST** *Traffic in Souls*, 1913 — "melodrama, social indictment and documentary" at once, says the Library of Congress.

**MOST WATCHED** *Erin Brockovich*, 2000 — \$258m.

### 5. Biopic

One real life compressed into a shape: the rise, the cost, the moment they became the name.

**FIRST** *Jeanne d'Arc*, 1900, Méliès — eleven minutes, and the earliest film anyone files as a biopic.

**MOST WATCHED** *Michael*, 2026 — the first biopic past a billion.

## ACTION

### 1. Swashbuckler

Sword-fighting adventure with a grinning hero who leaps, duels and rescues. Never grim.

**FIRST** *The Mark of Zorro*, 1920 — Douglas Fairbanks more or less wrote the job description.

**MOST WATCHED** *Pirates of the Caribbean: Dead Man's Chest*, 2006 — \$1.07bn.

### 2. Martial arts

The fights are the storytelling: trained bodies, choreography, and a code the hero has to earn.

**FIRST** *The Burning of the Red Lotus Temple*, 1928 — Shanghai, silent, and eighteen sequels.

**MOST WATCHED** *The Karate Kid*, 2010 — \$359m.

### 3. Spy

Cover identities and betrayal. The weapon is information, and nobody is who they say they are.

**FIRST** None settled — British shorts of 1913 and 1914 come first; Lang's *Spione*, 1928, set the moves still in use.

**MOST WATCHED** *Skyfall*, 2012 — \$1.11bn.

### 4. Disaster

A crowd of strangers against something overwhelming. The question is who survives, not who did it.

**FIRST** *Deluge*, 1933 — lost for fifty years, and found again in 1981.

**MOST WATCHED** *Titanic*, 1997 — \$2.26bn.

### 5. Heist

A crew assembles, plans an impossible robbery in detail, does it, and then the plan comes apart.

**FIRST** Disputed — *The Asphalt Jungle*, 1950, or *Rififi*, 1955.

**MOST WATCHED** *Ocean's Eleven*, 2001 — \$451m.

## HORROR

### 1. Gothic

Dread built out of place and inheritance: an old house, a family curse, and a building that seems to want something.

**FIRST** Disputed — *Le Manoir du diable*, 1896, has the furniture; gothic cinema proper is usually dated to *Caligari*, 1920, or *Nosferatu*, 1922.

**MOST WATCHED** *Bram Stoker's Dracula*, 1992 — \$216m. Gothic is a mood, not a box-office category.

### 2. Vampire

An undead predator who has to be invited in, feeds on blood, and turns attraction into something catching.

**FIRST** *Nosferatu*, 1922 — the earliest that survives. *Drakula halála*, 1921, came first, but the film is lost and nobody can say what was in it.

**MOST WATCHED** *Breaking Dawn – Part 2*, 2012 — \$868m.

### 3. Creature

One oversized animal or monster hunts people while the authorities stand around arguing about it.

**FIRST** Disputed — *The Lost World*, 1925, for stop motion; *King Kong*, 1933, for the template; *Godzilla*, 1954, for the man in the suit.

**MOST WATCHED** *Jurassic World*, 2015 — \$1.67bn. Keep it to the B-picture strand and it is *Jaws*, 1975 — \$495m.

### 4. Possession

A body is occupied by something intelligent and evil, and faith rather than force is the only weapon that works.

**FIRST** Not *The Exorcist* — possession films come before 1973. But it wrote the grammar every one since has used.

**MOST WATCHED** *The Exorcist*, 1973 — \$431m across its releases.

### 5. Slasher

A masked killer works through a group of young people one at a time, and one of them is left to face him.

**FIRST** Nobody agrees. *Psycho* and *Peeping Tom*, both 1960; *A Bay of Blood*, 1971; *Black Christmas*, 1974; *Halloween*, 1978, fixed the formula.

**MOST WATCHED** *Halloween*, 2018 — \$260m.

## SCIENCE FICTION

### 1. Outer space

Getting off the Earth is the engine of the story, and the vacuum supplies the danger.

**FIRST** *Le Voyage dans la Lune*, 1902, Méliès — with his own earlier trick films laying a claim.

**MOST WATCHED** *Star Wars: The Force Awakens*, 2015 — \$2.07bn.

### 2. Aliens

Something not human makes contact, and the real subject is whether we answer with curiosity or a weapon.

**FIRST** *Le Voyage dans la Lune*, 1902 — the Selenites are the first aliens anybody filmed.

**MOST WATCHED** *Avatar*, 2009 — \$2.92bn.

### 3. Apocalypse

Civilisation has already fallen. The film is about what the survivors eat, build and turn into.

**FIRST** Unsettled — *Verdens Undergang*, 1916, for the fall itself; *Deluge*, 1933, and *Five*, 1951, for what comes after, though that claim is asserted more often than sourced.

**MOST WATCHED** *I Am Legend*, 2007 — \$586m.

### 4. Cyberpunk

A near future run by corporations, where bodies and minds can be hacked and the hero is a low-life specialist.

**FIRST** *Blade Runner*, 1982 — four years older than the word. *Metropolis*, 1927, is named as an ancestor, not an origin.

**MOST WATCHED** *The Matrix Reloaded*, 2003 — \$742m.

### 5. Fantasy

Magic, myth or another world running on its own rules, and nobody in the film asks for a scientific explanation.

**FIRST** No settled credit. Everyone points at Méliès's trick films — *Le Manoir du diable*, 1896, then *Cendrillon*, 1899.

**MOST WATCHED** *Ne Zha 2*, 2025 — \$2.22bn.

Twenty-five bins, every one of them a sub-genre on the chart the club works from — which is also why Fantasy is a bin inside Science Fiction rather than a lane of its own.

Where the first film is genuinely argued over the bin says so rather than picking a winner, which turns out to be most of them. The last two lanes are what Europe files together as **fantastic cinema**: horror, science fiction and fantasy as one family, the word Sitges has used since 1968 and the festivals federation took for its name. They arrive together too. Méliès was making all three between 1896 and 1902, and which of them came first is an argument about labels nobody had invented yet.

# ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

A **genre switch** is a deliberate change of genre inside one film. It works when the first promise has been kept so well that the break feels like a betrayal, and then gives you something worth being betrayed for.

## WHY THESE FILMS, AND WHY LAST

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story. This chapter is the promise made before the shape begins. So the season ends where it started, with the rules: two films, one that keeps them to the end and one that breaks them halfway through, and arrives anyway. Next time you are in a theatre, ask which one the film is doing.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: [heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com](mailto:heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com)

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the BFI, the Library of Congress, the Academy's awards database, Dartmouth's film-genre guides, Box Office Mojo, The Numbers, Guinness World Records, Roger Ebert and Film Comment. Box-office figures are worldwide gross except where marked. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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